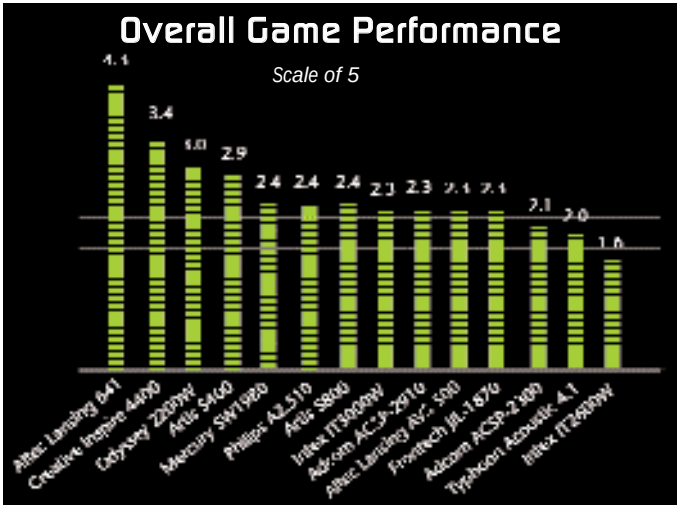




Philips has its main volume control on the front right satellite, while the Creative has a wired remote.

Conclusion

Though the RMS rating and performance of the Altec Lansing 641 4.1 was way above all the other contenders, its price is just as steep—almost four times more than the rest. This is definitely the best 4.1 speaker system money can buy, but for Rs 4,000 more, you can get the Creative Megaworks 5.1, which offers a higher RMS, performance and the 5.1 channel experience.

We awarded the performance crown to the Creative Inspire 4.1. It can play anything you want with aplomb, and has rich sound. The Frontech JIL-1870 was the value winner. It was average in terms of performance, but for just Rs 1750, the speaker is a good deal if you aren't too much into gaming or movies. Music is okay on these speakers, but don't even think of turning the volume all the way up.



5.1 SPEAKERS

The one major advantage 5.1 speakers have over the 4.1 variety, is the centre channel. This channel is used for the vocals, and performs a crucial part when viewing a DVD movie. Overall, a decent set of 5.1 speakers is better than any 4.1 set of speakers, in terms of sound quality. Let's find out which 5.1 set triumphed.

Performance

In our gaming tests, the Artis X10 and the Creative Megaworks ruled the roost. Nothing can beat the *Quake III* scene where the cigar falls on the ground—the boom shook the Test Centre's windows! The Artis did not achieve the fidelity that the Creative was capable of, but gave it a fair run for its money. The Creative 5700D could not match either in terms of muscle power, but its acoustic clarity was simply amazing. We used the optical out to test the

speakers, and give it two thumbs up for reproducing the finest of sounds. However, pumping up the volume resulted in distortion that was disappointing. We did not expect it to hold its own against the monsters, but it did a pretty good job. The Philips A3.610 was another good entrant, but the flat panel satellites ruined the show when the volume was turned up. The subwoofer provided deep percussive beats, but the satellites sounded too harsh, and we had to turn it down almost immediately.

Our movie tests were a display of audio prowess. The Creative 5700D was unmatched by any speaker in terms of clarity and qual-



The 5.1 sets say "Cheese", as they pose for a photograph

